

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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SESSION TWO

Be Still and Become Present

Day 1, afternoon

Before you begin

You have had a break, a meal, perhaps a walk or a sleep. Before you sit down, notice whether your mind has drifted back to the envelope. That is normal on the first afternoon. Notice it without judgement. Unless you realise that you placed an urgent safety, health, or caregiving matter inside, leave it sealed until Day 3.

Have your Bible, your journal, and your timer. This session is slower than the first, and it contains the longest silence so far. If ten minutes was your limit this morning, stay there. Nothing in this session requires more.

Central passage

Psalm 46

Read the whole psalm twice. The second time, notice how much noise there is in it before verse 10.

Teaching

"Be still, and know that I am God" is one of the most quoted lines in the Bible, and it is almost always quoted out of its setting. Read the psalm from the beginning and the setting is anything but still.

The earth gives way. Mountains fall into the sea. Waters roar and foam. Nations rage and kingdoms totter. Verse 10 arrives in the middle of a world coming apart. In context, the command appears to confront the raging nations: cease, and recognise the God who will be exalted among them. The Hebrew verb can carry the sense of ceasing, letting go, or becoming slack. It is less an invitation to create a peaceful mood than a command to stop striving against God's sovereignty. Its original force is larger than private contemplation, though it can still reshape how an individual believer responds to turmoil.

That matters for this session, because the stillness the psalm describes is not the stillness of a calm world. It is the stillness of a person who knows something true in the middle of a world that is not calm. "God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble." Present. Not distant, not delayed, not waiting for the trouble to end. "Present" does not mean you will necessarily feel calm or experience God vividly. It means that trouble does not place you beyond his knowledge, sovereignty, or care.

Much of the time, our attention is divided. We anticipate what is coming, replay what has happened, and mentally return to responsibilities elsewhere. The body is in the room and the attention is in tomorrow's meeting, last month's conversation, the people at home, the thing we should have said. This is such a normal condition that we rarely notice it, and it is tiring, because we are in two places and fully in neither. Jesus addressed it in the Sermon on the Mount: "do not be anxious about tomorrow, for tomorrow will be anxious for itself. Sufficient for the day is its own trouble" (Matthew 6:34). He is not shaming people who experience anxiety or forbidding wise preparation for tomorrow. He is challenging the attempt to carry tomorrow's burden before tomorrow arrives. For someone living with an anxiety disorder,

returning attention to the present may require professional care as well as spiritual practice, and there is no shame in that.

There is a second picture of stillness in the Gospels that belongs beside the psalm. In **Mark 4:35–41**, Jesus is asleep in the stern of a boat while a storm fills it with water. The disciples, several of them experienced fishermen, are terrified. They wake him, and he speaks to the sea: "Peace! Be still!" The wind and sea become calm. Then he turns to them: "Why are you so afraid? Have you still no faith?"

Jesus was able to sleep while the storm raged. The text may suggest exhaustion, trust, or both, but it does not describe his inner state in detail. When he woke, he spoke with authority, and the calm came from who he was and what he commanded, not from a technique. The disciples' fear was understandable because the danger was real. Jesus' question about faith does not mean that noticing danger is sinful. It exposes how difficult it was for them, in their terror, to interpret the storm in light of the person who was with them.

This afternoon's work is to become present. Not to make the storms stop, and not to pretend they are not there, but to bring your attention back into the room, into this hour, into this body, and to remember that God is here too. Greater presence can help you engage lament, confession, release, and listening more honestly in the sessions ahead. But divided attention does not disqualify your prayer. God receives you even while you are learning to return.

Self-assessment

Briefly, in your journal:

1. Right now, where is your attention? In this room, or somewhere else? If somewhere else, where: the past, the future, another place, another person?
2. When you try to bring your attention back to now, what pulls it away again? Name the strongest pull.
3. On a scale from "mostly attentive to this room" to "strongly pulled elsewhere," where would you place yourself? No right answer.
4. What situation currently feels unstable, loud, or beyond your control? Name it in one line without analysing or solving it. If you feel unreal, disconnected from your body, unable to recognise where you are, or as though you are reliving another time, pause the session and use the grounding and support guidance from Chapter 5.

Guided prayer

God, you are a very present help.

*I have been living somewhere else: ahead of myself,
behind myself, beside myself.*

*I bring my attention back to this room, this hour, this
body.*

The storm is real.

I am not going to pretend it is not.

But Christ is with me in it.

*Teach me to be still, not because the world has gone
quiet, but because you are here.*

Help me to cease striving for the rest of this day.

Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: fifteen minutes. If that is beyond you, return to the length you managed this morning. If it is well within you, stay with fifteen; there is no need to extend it.

Anchor phrase: **"Be still, and know that I am God."** Or, shorter: **"God is here."**

Before you begin, spend the first minute simply noticing where you are: the chair or the ground beneath you, the light, the sounds inside and outside the room. Notice only what feels neutral and manageable. If bodily attention increases distress, focus on visible objects, colours, or the words of the psalm instead. Then move to the phrase.

Each time you realise you have travelled somewhere else, the past, the future, the envelope, do not scold yourself. Notice where you went, and come back. The coming back is the practice. Each return is simply part of it. When you return without scolding yourself, you are learning that distraction does not have to become failure.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. Where did your attention go during the silence? List the places. Which one did it return to most often?
2. When have you recognised, or felt, God's help in your life? If you cannot identify such a time, say so honestly. Your inability to recall an experience does not make the psalm's declaration untrue, and Session Seven will return to this.

3. The disciples were afraid because the boat was filling. What reasonable fear makes it difficult for you to remember or trust that Christ remains with you?
4. Finish this sentence: "If I gave this present moment my attention without trying to solve the past or anticipate the future, I would notice..."

Practical exercise: a walk of noticing

This exercise takes twenty to thirty minutes and is best done outdoors, though a window, a garden, a corridor, or a different room will do. If walking is not possible for you, sit somewhere new, ideally with a view, and do the same exercise without moving. Use mobility aids or remain seated as needed.

Leave ordinary digital input behind. If safety permits, leave the phone in your room. If you need it for emergencies, carry it out of sight with your retreat setting active and only the designated contact permitted to ring through. Do not use it for photographs, messages, music, or checking information during the walk.

Walk at a comfortable, unhurried pace that is safe for your body and surroundings, and give your attention to one sense at a time.

For the first few minutes, notice only what you can see. Colours, light, movement, small things you would normally walk past. You may simply observe, or quietly name what you see if that helps you stay oriented. The purpose is not to analyse or evaluate it.

Then, for a few minutes, notice only what you can hear. The near sounds and the far ones. The sounds you would normally filter out.

Then what you can feel: the ground under your feet, the air on your skin, the temperature, your own breathing if that is comfortable for you.

Then, if you are outdoors, what you can smell.

Finally, walk the last few minutes with all of it at once, simply present in the place where you are, repeating your anchor phrase if it helps.

If focusing closely on one sense becomes uncomfortable, use whichever sense feels most neutral, or take in the environment more generally. You do not have to complete every stage.

This is not a technique for producing a spiritual experience, and you may feel nothing in particular. The purpose is practice in being where you are. Present-moment attention can often be strengthened through practice, though each person's capacity is affected by health, exhaustion, trauma, and how their mind works. The goal is not perfect concentration but repeated, compassionate return. The retreat will ask you to be present many times in the next two days. This is the first rehearsal.

If you feel unsafe, faint, confused, severely distressed, or disoriented, stop moving and go to the nearest safe, familiar place. Contact your designated person or appropriate help. Do not continue walking, and do not drive, while disoriented. Do not walk somewhere unfamiliar or unsafe in the name of noticing.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

God is a very present help.

The storm is real, and Christ is with me in it.

I am learning to be here, in this hour, in this place.

Every time I wander, I will come back.

Notes

Space for anything else you want to record from this session.

Ending Day 1: Session Two closes the first day. If the three-day program in Part Four is your guide, the evening is unstructured: a simple meal, rest, perhaps some time outside or with a psalm. Do not add another session.

Today you practised two movements: from performance to welcome, and from divided attention to presence. You do not need to master either before sleeping. You have begun.

Sleep when you are tired. Day 2 begins in the morning with Session Three. It moves toward deeper material, but it will continue at the same gentle, adjustable pace. You do not have to resolve everything that surfaces.